

Jamiatul Ulama Johannesburg

محرم وعاشوراء — دليل الصيام المسنون

Muḥarram & Āshūrā — Sunnah Fasting Guide

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وما علينا إلا البلاغ المبين

"Clear propagation is our only responsibility." — Sūrah Yāsīn 36:17

The Sacred Month of Muḥarram

الشهر الحرام محرم

إن عدة الشهور عند الله اثنا عشر شهرا في كتاب الله يوم خلق السماوات والأرض منها أربعة حرم

Muḥarram is the first month of the Islamic Hijri calendar and one of the four sacred (ḥurum) months mentioned in the Qur'ān. Allah says: "Indeed, the number of months with Allah is twelve in the register of Allah from the day He created the heavens and the earth; of these, four are sacred." (Sūrah al-Tawbah 9:36)

The four sacred months are: Muḥarram, Rajab, Dhul-Qa'dah, and Dhul-Ḥijjah. Good deeds in these months carry greater reward, and sins carry greater weight.

The Prophet ﷺ said: "The best of fasting after Ramaḍān is the month of Allah, Muḥarram." (Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1163)

Source: Sūrah al-Tawbah 9:36 · Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1163



The Day of Āshūrā (10th Muḥarram)

يوم عاشوراء

صيام يوم عاشوراء أحتسب على الله أن يكفر السنة التي قبله

Āshūrā falls on the 10th of Muḥarram. The Prophet ﷺ said: "Fasting the day of Āshūrā, I hope that Allah will expiate the sins of the year before it." (Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1162)

When the Prophet ﷺ arrived in Madīnah, he found the Jews fasting on this day in commemoration of Mūsā 'alayhis-salām being saved from Fir'aun. He ﷺ said: "We have more right to Mūsā than they." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2003)

The Prophet ﷺ was told that the Jews of Madīnah fasted only on the 10th. He ﷺ said: "If I live until next year, I will surely fast on the 9th." (Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1134) — to differ from the practice of the People of the Book.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2003 · Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1162, 1134



The Sunnah Method of Fasting Āshūrā

طريقة صيام عاشوراء المسنونة

The Sunnah is to fast on TWO days, to differ from the Jews who fast only the 10th:

Option 1 (preferred — the practice of the Prophet in his final intention): Fast on the 9th and 10th of Muḥarram.

Option 2: Fast on the 10th and 11th of Muḥarram.

If one fasts only the 10th, the fast is valid and the reward is attained, but the recommended practice is to add either the 9th or the 11th.

The 9th of Muḥarram is called Tāsū'ā. The 10th is Āshūrā.

For the year 1448 AH: Āshūrā falls on Friday, 26 June 2026. The 9th falls on Thursday, 25 June 2026. The 11th falls on Saturday, 27 June 2026.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1134 · Sunan Abī Dāwūd 2445



Historical Significance

الأهمية التاريخية

The 10th of Muḥarram is the day on which Allah saved Mūsā 'alayhis-salām and his people from Fir'aun, and drowned Fir'aun and his army. Mūsā 'alayhis-salām fasted this day in gratitude to Allah.

Other significant events that scholars have mentioned as occurring on Āshūrā:

- The repentance of Ādam 'alayhis-salām was accepted.
- The ark of Nūḥ 'alayhis-salām came to rest on Mount Judī.
- Ibrāhīm 'alayhis-salām was born.
- The martyrdom of Ḥusayn ibn 'Alī at Karbalā' occurred on the 10th of Muḥarram, 61 AH.

The martyrdom of Ḥusayn is a tragedy that grieved the entire Ummah, but the innovation (bid'ah) of mourning ceremonies, chest-beating, and self-flagellation has no basis in the Sunnah and is contrary to the practice of the Salaf.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2003 · Classical Tafsīr works



Recommended Acts on Āshūrā

الأعمال المستحبة في عاشوراء

1. Fasting on the 9th and 10th (or 10th and 11th). This is the primary Sunnah.
2. Increased generosity (ṣadaqah) — the Prophet said: "Whoever is generous to his family on the day of Āshūrā, Allah will be generous to him for the entire year." (Reported by al-Bayhaqī; scholars have differed on its authenticity, but many scholars of the past acted upon it.)
3. Increased dhikr, recitation of the Qur'ān, and du'ā.
4. Reconciliation of broken relationships.
5. Visiting the sick and the elderly.

Note: Some fabricated practices have been attributed to Āshūrā (e.g. cooking a special dish, applying kohl, taking a special bath). These have no basis in the Sunnah.

Source: Sunan al-Bayhaqī · verified Fatāwā collections



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